

May

20



1498

Passage to India

Portuguese explorer Vasco da Gama arrived at Calicut in India, ensuring his place in history by becoming the first European to reach India by sea. The breakthrough route enabled Portuguese colonists to begin trading with Asia.

1999

Grand Canyon jump

Daredevil US motorcyclist Robbie Knievel jumped 69 m (228 ft) across the Grand Canyon in Arizona, USA, to a backdrop of fireworks as viewers watched on live TV. He lost control of his vehicle on landing and broke his leg.



Monkey business

2005

Scientists announced their discovery of a new species of monkey. The kipunji lives in the highland forests of Tanzania, Africa, and has a population of just over 1,000.

Born this day

1908 James Stewart, US actor. He starred in the Christmas classic *It's A Wonderful Life*.

1946 Cher, US singer and songwriter. Known for her eclectic style, she has enjoyed a career in music and film spanning six decades.

Also on this day

1570 The first modern atlas, called *Theatrum Orbis Terrarum* (Theatre of the World), was released by Flemish cartographer Abraham Ortelius.

1927 US aviator Charles Lindbergh flew from New York City, USA, to Paris, France, in the first solo transatlantic flight.

1990 NASA's Hubble Space Telescope took its first photograph – a spectacular starry image of the Pincushion Cluster in the Carina constellation.